‘deeply emersed in state affairs’ one moment and ‘the next . . . shearing camels, hewing stones, cutting wood, or hammering iron, and doing all with as much diligence as though engaged in his own particular vocation’.[10]

Akbar enjoyed all kinds of arts, crafts and technologies. His ‘household’, writes Abul Fazl, included ‘over one hundred offices and workshops each resembling a city, or rather a little kingdom’.[11] It was in these workshops – *karkhana*s – that Akbar promoted carpet-weaving, for example, with such success that Indian carpets surpassed their Persian counterparts in quality. ‘His Majesty has such an eye for the finer things,’ wrote a contemporary writer on Akbar’s interest in textiles, ‘that he has introduced [lit. invented] silken clothes, brocade, tapestry and carpets of silk, and brocade in India, and instructed highly skilled masters in the art, so that the work in India is now much better than the work of Persia and Europe.’[12] The gold and silver minted in his realm was of such high quality that some suspected ‘witchcraft or alchemy’.[13] Akbar’s patronage of painting is splendidly clear from the profusion of art produced during his reign (of those in his court who disapproved of painting, Akbar said, ‘such men I dislike’[14]). He loved music, too. Abul Fazl describes how an orchestra of drums, trumpets, horns and cymbals would play at midnight and dawn in Akbar’s court, culminating in seven kinds of melodies – many composed by Akbar himself, who was also, it seems, a dab hand at the naqqara, kettledrum – followed by a ‘reading of beautiful sentences and poems’.[15] The emperor’s *khushbu-khana*, in which the Jesuits lived for a few days, contained jars upon jars of ‘ointments, perfumes and . . . scented water’.[16] Akbar was ‘very fond of perfume’, writes Abul Fazl; the scent of amber or aloe, flowers and incense filled his court, and the emperor himself dabbled in inventing ‘mixtures’.[17]

Dabbling, tinkering, inventing were among Akbar’s great pleasures. Abul Fazl, of course, is glad to ascribe any innovation in the realm to Akbar’s genius, but this is not only, or always, flattery. Irfan Habib examines some of these claims in an essay and finds some of them quite legitimate: that Akbar first had the idea of using khus frames to cool the air, for example, or that he discovered the use of saltpetre to cool water.[18]

The Ibadat Khana debates, in this light, were a kind of tinkering, too: a physical manifestation, a playing out of belief. The Jesuits were invited, as